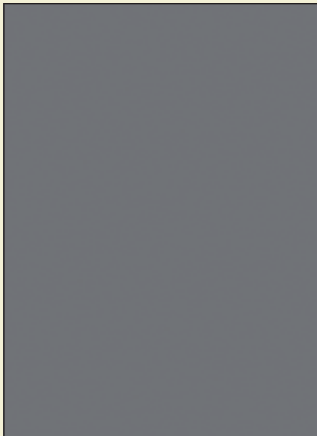




A sample grey card

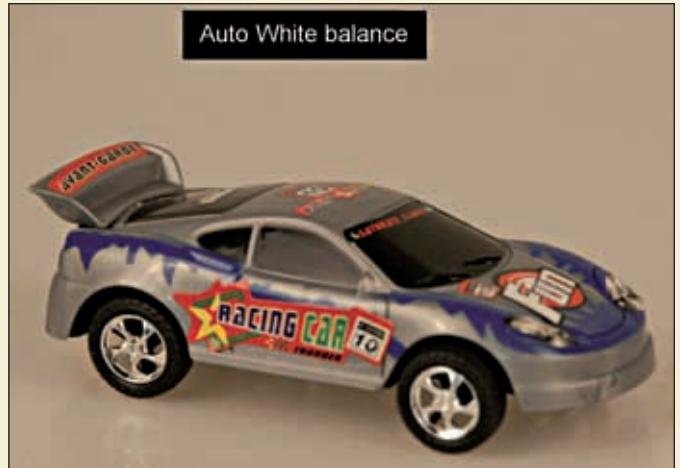
exposure is about one stop off. Compensate accordingly when you take photos and you're set! Works with brown paper bags as well. Of course, metering off any object that you believe is closest to 18 per cent grey can also work.

Playing with white balance

As mentioned earlier, adjusting white balance is a breeze when you use a grey card. However, there are many ways by which you can tweak the settings to get the colours or effects you'd want. Do you want to make day look like night? Just set your white balance to tungsten or incandescent, set exposure compensation at -2ev and voila! Day is now night! Of course, you might still need to tweak the image a bit.

Here's a small cheat sheet to make things easier...

- **Tungsten / Incandescent:** Extremely blue, except indoors with no natural light source
- **Daylight:** Close to normal but with a mild bluish cast
- **Shady:** Warmer than daylight with no bluish cast



Auto white balance cannot always expose the scene correctly

- **Fluorescent:** Corrects the green tinge under fluorescent light, especially white artificial light such as that from tubelights or CFLs

Custom white balance settings can be found on almost all cameras, including certain mobile phone cameras. A simple trick to adjust the value is to follow the Kelvin scale of temperature. Think of a fire, the hotter it is, the bluer it gets (upto a certain point). Custom WB works in the same way, the higher the value, the bluer the image, so the lower the amount of light, the higher the kelvin value that you need to set.

Shooting fireworks and lightning

Fireworks and lightning have long been the bane of amateur

photographers all over the world. Getting the shot just right is difficult and there are so many things such as exposure, aperture and shutter speed to juggle. What's the ideal setting? There's no such thing.

A very simple way of getting great shots of lightning and/or fireworks is to first point your camera at a spot where you think that rocket will burst or hope that lightning will strike. Set a long exposure manually for, say, 30 seconds. Set the aperture to a value of around f/8 or f/11. Now, release the shutter. Keep your hand over the lens while the shutter is open and only remove it when you think the rocket or whatever will explode in front of the lens! It's as simple as that. The same goes for lightning except that it's best



Shot taken in the afternoon at auto settings



Shot taken at the afternoon with incandescent white balance



This shot can be very hard to get if you don't know how